Prompt Framing Experiment: Procrastination and Time Management

1. Objective

This experiment demonstrates how different prompt framing produces vastly different outputs while addressing the exact same core request. The underlying intent for all three prompts is: "How to overcome procrastination and manage time better."

Open three separate, fresh Gemini chat windows and paste one prompt into each. Using fresh windows is essential, because earlier messages in a chat act as context and would contaminate the comparison.

2. Experiment Setup

Variant	Framing Style	Key Technique	Expected Output
A	Minimal / Vague	Single-sentence request with no context	Generic, broad list of common tips
B	Structured / Constrained	Role, context, task, constraints and format	Focused, concise, formatted answer
C	Interactive / Personalized	Persona, clarifying questions, step-by-step plan	Dialogue-driven, tailored action plan

- **Control:** Use the same model and version in all three windows.
- **Repetition:** Run each prompt once first, then repeat two more times to see the natural variation.
- **Recording:** Save each response as text or screenshot with the variant label.

3. The Three Prompts

3.1 Prompt A: Minimal

```
I want to stop procrastinating and manage my time better. Help me.
```

3.2 Prompt B: Structured

```
Role: You are an evidence-based productivity coach.
Context: I am a working professional who delays important tasks,
  gets distracted by my phone, and often works late to meet deadlines.
Task: Explain how to overcome procrastination and manage time better.
Constraints:
  - Use techniques backed by research (e.g., time-boxing, 2-minute
rule).
  - Keep each tip actionable within 10 minutes.
  - Maximum 400 words.
Format: A numbered list of 7 strategies, each with a one-line example,
  followed by a short summary table.
```

3.3 Prompt C: Interactive Coach

```
You are a behavioral psychologist and time-management mentor.
```

```
Do not give advice yet. First, ask me 5 diagnostic questions to find
out
why I procrastinate (fear of failure, boredom, perfectionism,
overwhelm).
After I answer, do the following:
  1. Identify my main procrastination pattern.
  2. Build a personalized 7-day action plan with daily 25-minute tasks.
  3. Add a fallback plan for days when I fail to follow the plan.
  4. Close with one accountability check-in question.
Think step by step and keep a supportive, non-judgmental tone.
```

4. Expected Differences

Dimension	Prompt A	Prompt B	Prompt C
Length	Medium to long, unpredictable	Controlled, about 400 words	Short first reply (questions only)
Structure	Loose headings and bullets	Numbered list plus table	Questions, then a day-by-day plan
Personalization	Very low	Medium (uses given context)	High (uses your answers)
Actionability	General advice	Specific, time-bound tips	Scheduled tasks with fallback
Effort required from you	Minimal	Moderate (write the prompt)	Highest (answer questions)

5. Evaluation Rubric

Score each response from 1 (poor) to 5 (excellent) for every criterion. Add the totals to compare the three variants objectively.

Criterion	What to Look For	A	B	C
Relevance	Addresses procrastination and time management directly			
Specificity	Concrete steps rather than generic statements			
Actionability	Can be started today without further research			
Format Control	Follows requested length and structure			
Personal Fit	Adapted to the user's situation			
Total (max 25)	Sum of all scores			

6. Analysis: Why the Outputs Differ

Prompt A leaves every decision to the model. With no role, audience, length or format, the model falls back on the most statistically common answer: a generic list including the Pomodoro technique, prioritization matrices and removing distractions. The result is correct but interchangeable, and could have been written for anyone.

Prompt B narrows the output space. Assigning a role sets tone and expertise, the context removes irrelevant advice, and the constraints and format make the answer easy to scan and compare. This is the best choice when you need a predictable, reusable deliverable.

Prompt C changes the interaction pattern. By forbidding immediate advice and requesting diagnostic questions, it shifts the model from answering to consulting. Because procrastination has different root causes (fear, perfectionism, overwhelm), advice based on your real answers is more likely to work.

6.1 Prompting Principles Demonstrated

- **Role assignment:** Specifying who the model should be changes vocabulary, depth and tone.
- **Context injection:** Details about the user filter out irrelevant advice.
- **Constraints:** Word limits, counts and time limits reduce padding.
- **Output format:** Tables, numbered lists and sections shape readability.
- **Clarifying questions:** Asking questions first turns a monologue into a tailored conversation.

6.2 Limitations to Keep in Mind

- A single run is anecdotal; language models vary between runs, so repeat each prompt.
- A longer prompt is not automatically better. Unnecessary detail can distract the model.
- Prompt C needs a second turn from you, so compare it only after you have answered its questions.
- Research-backed claims in any output should be verified before you rely on them.

7. Bonus: Improved Combined Prompt

After running the experiment, combine the strengths of B and C into a single reusable prompt:

```
Act as an evidence-based productivity coach.
Ask me up to 3 short questions about my work habits and main
distractions.
Then give a personalized plan with:
  - 5 strategies, each doable in under 10 minutes
  - one 7-day starter schedule in a table
  - a fallback step for days I miss the plan
Keep the total under 500 words and use a supportive tone.
```

8. Conclusion

The same intent can yield a generic list, a precise formatted guide, or a personalized coaching session purely through framing. Clear role, context, constraints and interaction design are what turn an average answer into a useful one. Use Prompt A for quick exploration, Prompt B for reusable content, and Prompt C when personal fit matters most.